



# SAFETY FIRST

Like all good things in life, the Internet has its dark side—which you want to veer clear of

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For the most part, the Internet is a friendly place. But as you know all too well, you can't just connect and leave your cares behind—at least, you *should* know. Computer crime, for example, is evolving: from the early-day e-mails promising you pots of cash to the more sophisticated phishing and botnet attacks of today. The good thing is, it's not difficult to stay clear of trouble—all you need is to be aware of what could go wrong.

## The Basics

Surfing the Internet on an unprotected computer is an extremely risky proposition, and if you've been doing that, just go into your Program Files folder. You will almost certainly find programs you don't remember installing. Most damage to your computer happens when you don't take care to have the basic lines of defence installed—anti-virus, firewall, and anti-spyware. As impor-

tant as it is to install them, so it is to keep them updated. Avast! Home Edition (anti-virus), ZoneAlarm (firewall), and Spybot—Search and Destroy (anti-spyware) are some of the popular free programs you can use. You can find these in the Essentials section of any of our monthly CDs. Run full virus and spyware scans from time to time—say about once every one or two weeks.

Another important step is keeping your operating system updated. Setting the Automatic Updates to “notify” you will ensure that you are aware of new updates for Windows to download (assuming you're using Windows). Then, never have the same password for all your e-mail IDs, nor for your bank accounts—it's something like keeping all your eggs in one basket. Also, never e-mail yourself the password for any service on the Internet. You don't want to have your e-mail account compromised *and* give access to all your other accounts to the attacker, would you? Visiting “cracks” and “warez” sites is another potential way to get infected by spyware or a virus—it's dangerous, and you shouldn't be doing it anyway!

It is advisable to heed Google's warning message—like the one above—that shows up for dangerous sites. If you use Internet Explorer 6 (to check this, open IE, and go to Help > About Internet Explorer), it is highly recommended to update to IE7, which is more secure. This is a free download, available at <http://tinyurl.com/38m4oj>. We should also say that Firefox ([www.getfirefox.com](http://www.getfirefox.com)) and Opera ([www.opera.com](http://www.opera.com)) are more secure than IE.

Some Web sites offer screen savers, icons, and wallpapers as EXE downloads. Stay away from these—they are riddled with spyware and/or viruses more often than not. Also, scan any



If you try to visit a potentially dangerous site from a Google search, you'll see this message

e-mail attachment with your anti-virus before opening it.

## Kid Safety

In the case that you have kids at home, most “staying safe online” articles advise you to install parental monitoring software like NetPatrol and CyberNanny, which block access to Web sites and software. Truth be told, kids are smarter these days, and will soon devise ways to get around these blocks. You can't leave it all to a software: it is important to educate them on the dangers of the Internet and the perils of personally meeting new “friends” they make online. A good site to look up before educating your kids is [www.teenangels.org](http://www.teenangels.org) and [www.wiredsafety.org](http://www.wiredsafety.org).

It's a good idea to have the computer in the living room where you can monitor their activity. With their co-operation, you should also set up do's and don'ts like how many hours a day to use the computer, what kind of interactions they should have online, and so on.

## Stop-Think-Click

Most of us have this tendency to click “OK” or “Next” every time we see those buttons on an error message or Web page, without reading what the text above it says. This is also true when we install software—and this is how much unnecessary software gets installed on your computer, software that connects to the Internet without your knowledge, and which, in many cases, does you more harm than good. The same goes for pop-ups you encounter online. We're not telling you to be paranoid—just cautious and sensible: read what you're saying “OK” to!

## Personal Details

You want to be as anonymous on the Internet as possible—you never know when and where personal details can be used to your detriment. When you register at a site, it will ask you for personally identifiable information. Remember, you don't have to give out personal details just because a site asks you for them. Fill in the

mandatory fields—normally the ones with an asterisk—and then choose what other data you want to fill.

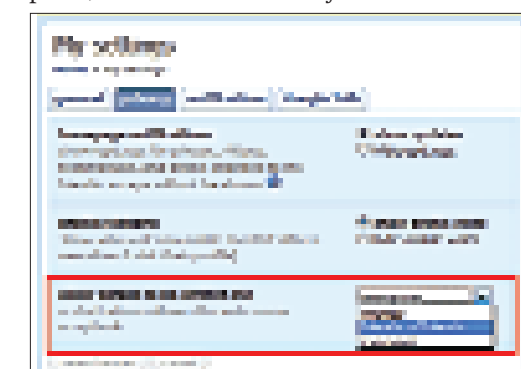
You might have already done some damage: searching for your full name in quotes on a search engine. This should bring up results of places where you have posted on the Web. Visit those result pages to check what personally identifiable information is there that needn't be, and edit those posts accordingly.

On social networking sites, where others can see your personal details, you can choose what details you want to show to random visitors and to your friends. It is, in general, a good idea to not add information like phone numbers, addresses, and alternate e-mail IDs to your profile. If you write about family and friends on your blog, it is best to keep the blog address off your profile as well.

Just remember: before you enter any information on the Web, think for a second about how this information could possibly be used against you.

## Online Fraud

These days, the possibility of being duped online is very real. This type of crime would generally make use of programs that record your usernames and passwords or your credit card details, also known as key-loggers. If you keep your anti-virus and firewall updated and run a complete system scan every week, you can be pretty sure you're safe. If you need to do online banking on a public computer, it is safest to enter your bank account



You can choose what information you want to display to whom on your profile

